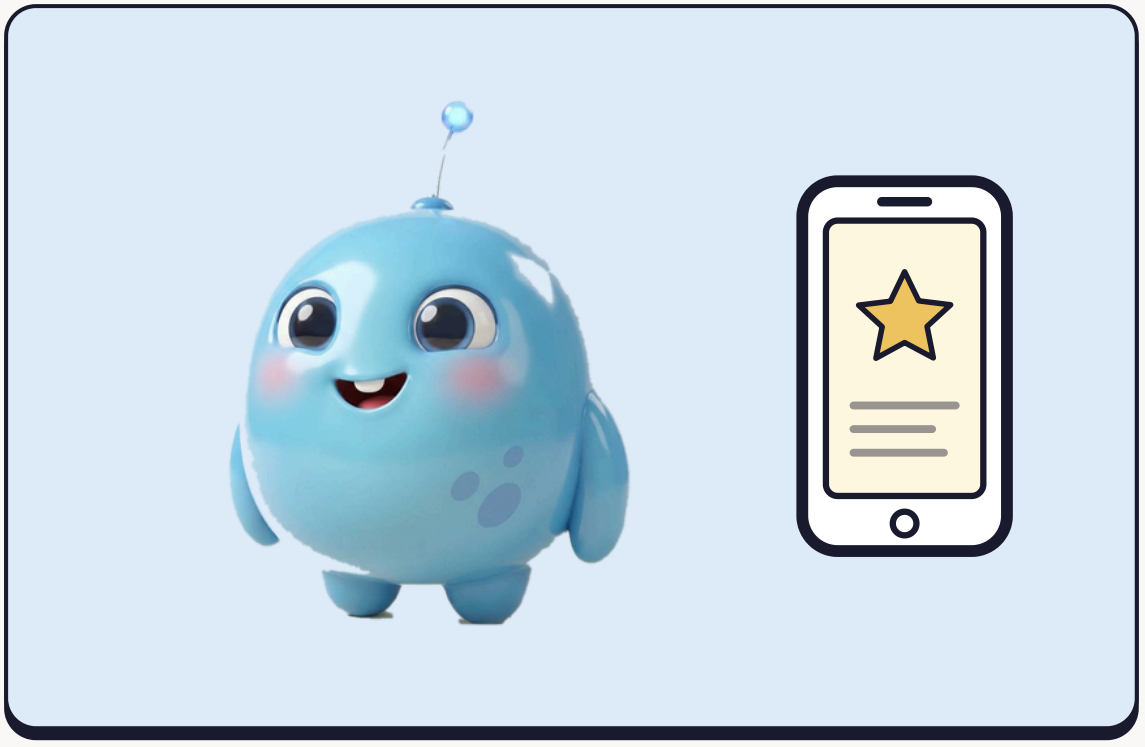
The First Phone Kit

The phone arrives with a plan, and the plan is made together.



The readiness check

My phone deal

Setup night

The first 30 days

The words for the wobbles

Orbit walks your family through it in four steps: an honest check, a deal your child writes, one evening of setup, and a month of small practice.

READ THIS FIRST · TEN MINUTES, BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

The phone arrives with a plan

A first phone usually turns up in a rush. A birthday, a new school, a box opened on the sofa and handed straight over. The rules come later, one argument at a time. This kit turns that round. You do four things, in this order, and the phone lands on a plan your child helped to make.

1 The check

PAGES 3 AND 4 · A FEW WEEKS BEFORE

Honest questions for your child and for you. Every answer is ready, nearly or not yet, and each one comes with the thing to practise next.

2 The deal

PAGES 5 AND 6 · THE WEEK BEFORE

Your child writes their phone deal in their own words. You add your promises. You both sign, and a date goes on the calendar to look at it again.

3 Setup night

PAGE 7 · THE NIGHT IT ARRIVES

One evening side by side, switching on the settings that hold the deal: the codes, the bedtime lock, the app approvals, the charger's new home.

4 The first 30 days

PAGES 8 TO 11 · THE MONTH AFTER

One small thing to practise each week, a tick a day, ten minutes at the weekend, and the words for the first wobbles.

SAY THIS OUT LOUD BEFORE THE BOX IS OPENED

"If you ever show me something bad on it, the phone stays yours. Telling me never costs you the phone."

The whole kit rests on this promise. Children go quiet when telling costs them the phone, so it goes first, before any settings, and it is the first promise in your half of the deal on page six.

SMARTPHONE, OR CALLS AND TEXTS?

The kit works for either. For eleven and twelve year olds, Guided Childhood suggests a first phone that does calls and texts with no apps, and a smartphone as the next step. Already chosen a smartphone? Every page is built for that too.



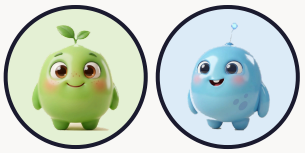
NINE OR TEN?

Bloop looks after ages eight to ten. Do the check and the deal now, while the phone is still a plan. Every decision is easier before the box is opened.



What you need: a pen each, this kit printed on A4, an evening with nothing else on, and the phone still in its box until page seven.

How ready am I for my phone?



Colour one circle on every line. Be honest. Not yet is a good answer: it tells us what to practise next. Then a grown up reads it with you.

1	**I put my screen down when someone talks to me.** PRACTISE For a week, screen face down the moment someone starts talking. Grown ups too.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
2	**My screens go to bed before I do, outside my room.** PRACTISE A tablet or console goes to its charger at the agreed time for a week, without being asked.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
3	**I can spend my screen time a bit at a time, not all in one go.** PRACTISE Split your time into two goes a day for a week, and notice which felt better.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
4	**I know exactly who I would tell if something felt wrong.** PRACTISE Name two grown ups out loud: one at home and one away from home.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
5	**I can make a strong password and keep it away from friends.** PRACTISE Make one together from three random words, and agree who is allowed to know it.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
6	**I know a stranger online is still a stranger.** PRACTISE Talk it through: someone you only know from a game sends you a message. What do you do?	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
7	**I can leave a screen in another room and not mind.** PRACTISE One evening this week with every screen in another room, the whole family.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
8	**I have shown a grown up how I would ask for help.** PRACTISE Act it out once: what you would say, and what you would show them.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET

How ready am I for their phone?



The same three answers, for you, and the same rule: honest beats impressive. Fill it in on your own, then show your child what you circled. Seeing you mark a not yet makes theirs easier to say.

1	**I can say what this phone is for in one sentence.** PRACTISE Agree the sentence with your child. It goes at the top of their deal on page five.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
2	**I know where it will charge at night, and my phone charges there too.** PRACTISE Move your own charger out of the bedroom this week, where they can see it.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
3	**I can stay calm if they show me something upsetting.** PRACTISE Have your first sentence ready: "I am really glad you told me." Then the promise from page two.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
4	**I know how to switch on the settings on this phone.** PRACTISE Read page seven once before setup night, and charge the phone before you start.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
5	**We have talked about group chats before there is one.** PRACTISE Ask: the class group turns mean at eleven at night. What would you do? Listen before you answer.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
6	**We already agree how screen time works in our house.** PRACTISE Name the three kinds out loud: a small core that is theirs, extra time earned through jobs, and protected times nobody can buy.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
7	**I put my own phone down where they can see me do it.** PRACTISE Say it when you stop: "I have been on that too long, I am putting it down."	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET
8	**I can say not yet without saying no.** PRACTISE Try: "Not yet, and here is what gets us there." Then name the next step together.	○ READY	○ NEARLY	○ NOT YET

READING BOTH PAGES TOGETHER

Mostly ready. Go on to the deal. The nearly lines become week one practice.

Mostly nearly. Pick two lines each, practise for a fortnight, then do the check again.

Mostly not yet. Good to know now. One line a week, check again in a month. Write the deal anyway.

No pass mark and no date. The check only ever tells you the next thing to practise.

STEP TWO · WRITTEN BY ME

My phone deal



My words, my handwriting. A grown up can help with spelling, never with choosing.

1 What I will use my phone for

Calling home? Music? Messaging my friends? My top three.

2 Where my phone sleeps at night

And the time it goes there.

3 If I see something that worries me, I will

Who I go to, and what I show them.

4 People I can call any time

5 When I want more time, I will

How will I ask? What will I do if the answer is not yet?

6 One rule I am adding myself

STEP TWO · THE GROWN UP'S HALF

Our promises to you

Read out loud before anyone signs. Your deal binds us too.

☆ **Telling us never costs you the phone.**
If something goes wrong, show us. Nobody is in trouble, and the phone stays yours.

☆ **Our phones sleep outside bedrooms too.**
The same spot, the same time, grown ups included.

☆ **No phones at the table, ours included.**
One meal a day where we actually talk.

☆ **Big decisions get talked through before they are made.**
If your deal needs changing, you hear about it first and you get a say.

☆ **One honest chat a week about how it is going.**
Your answers first, our questions second. The weekly questions are on pages eight and nine.

One promise of our own

SIGNED BY ME

MY NAME AND SIGNATURE

SIGNED BY US

GROWN UP'S NAME AND SIGNATURE

DATE

TODAY

We look at this deal again on:

AFTER THE FIRST 30 DAYS

NEXT TERM

THE TERM AFTER

Keep both pages where you can both see them. A photo of the signed deal makes a good first picture for the new phone.

STEP THREE · THE NIGHT IT ARRIVES

Setup night checklist



Sit side by side and do it together, before the phone goes in a pocket. Phone menus move with every update, so this list says what to switch on, not where to tap. On an iPhone most of it lives in **Screen Time**. On Android it lives in **Google Family Link**, which is easiest set up before your child's Google account is made. Stuck? Search the settings for the words in bold.

- [ ] **Two codes.** The unlock code: you both know it. A separate code for the controls: only the grown up knows it. If one person knows both, the controls do nothing.

- [ ] **A bedtime lock** at the time on the deal. iPhone calls it Downtime; Family Link calls it bedtime. Only the apps you choose work after it starts.

- [ ] **Daily time limits** that match the deal. Start where the deal says, and change them at a review, never in the middle of an argument.

- [ ] **App approvals.** New apps and purchases ask a grown up first: Ask to Buy on iPhone, app approval in Family Link. If you only do one thing tonight, do this one.

- [ ] **Age ratings and safe search.** Set apps, films and music to their age, and switch safe search on.

- [ ] **Contacts.** Save the people from page five into the phone together, and choose who can still get through during the bedtime lock.

- [ ] **Location sharing, agreed out loud.** Decide together whether it is on, who can see it, and why. If it is on, they know it is on.

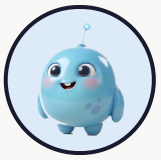
- [ ] **The charger's new home.** Plug it in tonight where the phone will sleep, outside the bedroom, and put yours there too. If the phone was going to be the alarm clock, a real alarm clock takes the job.

- [ ] **The weekly report.** Pick the evening you will look at it together. Look at it with them, not at them.



A calls and texts phone? Do the codes, the contacts, location and the charger. The rest is ready for when a smartphone comes along.

One small thing a week



Tick a box for each day it happened. A missed day stays empty: no catching up and no telling off, just start again tomorrow. At the weekend, ten minutes and the three questions. Your child answers first.

WEEK 1 · DAYS 1 TO 7

Phone to bed, unasked

At the time on the deal, the phone goes to its charger outside the bedroom without anyone asking. Grown ups' phones go too.

DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5	DAY 6	DAY 7
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

THE WEEKEND CHECK IN

What was the best thing your phone did for you this week?

What made bedtime easy, and what made it hard?

Did anyone need a reminder? Grown ups count.

WEEK 2 · DAYS 8 TO 14

Ask before you add

Every new app or game starts with a chat: what it is, who is on it, whether it costs anything. Then the approval on the phone.

DAY 8	DAY 9	DAY 10	DAY 11	DAY 12	DAY 13	DAY 14
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

THE WEEKEND CHECK IN

What was the best thing your phone did for you this week?

What did you ask for, and what did we decide together?

Was there anything you wanted but did not ask about?

Weeks three and four

WEEK 3 · DAYS 15 TO 21

Group chats sleep too

Chats get muted when the bedtime lock starts and opened again in the morning. Once this week, show a grown up one thing from a chat, good or bad.

DAY 15	DAY 16	DAY 17	DAY 18	DAY 19	DAY 20	DAY 21
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

THE WEEKEND CHECK IN

What was the best thing your phone did for you this week?

Which chat is the busiest, and what happens if you miss a bit of it?

Did anything in a chat bother you this week?

WEEK 4 · DAYS 22 TO 30

Show me your favourite

Ten minutes together on whatever they use most. They drive, you watch. Ask: "Why do you think it showed you that?"

DAY 22	DAY 23	DAY 24	DAY 25	DAY 26	DAY 27	DAY 28	DAY 29	DAY 30
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

THE WEEKEND CHECK IN

What was the best thing your phone did for you this week?

What did it show you that surprised you?

If you could change one thing about it, what would it be?

STEP FOUR · DAY 30

The first review



Ten minutes, something nice to eat, and the deal from pages five and six on the table. Your child answers first. Nothing on this page is a verdict. It decides the next step.

1 What did the phone make easier this month?

2 What was harder than we expected?

3 Which week's practice stuck, and which needs another go?

KEEP
What stays exactly as it is

LOOSEN
One thing that has earned more room

PRACTISE
One thing for next month



Changed something? Write it into the deal on page five, both initial it, and you are done. Then keep looking at it every term.

OUR NEXT REVIEW

FOR THE GROWN UP · KEEP THIS ONE BY THE CHARGER

The words for the first wobble



Four moments that often turn up in the first month, with the words from the Guided Childhood script library. Short on purpose, so they come back to you when you need them.

TOO LONG ON IT

"Five more minutes. Please."

Bedtime has already been stretched twice.

"I know. And we are done now. Device off. I will come in to say goodnight."

WHY The five more minutes negotiation reflects genuine disappointment, not defiance.

A GROUP CHAT UPSET

"Nothing. I am fine."

They came home quiet, and something happened in the group chat.

"Something happened in the group chat, didn't it. You don't have to tell me what. But I am here if you do."

WHY Naming what you can see and leaving the door open gets you more than demanding to see the evidence.

A NEW APP

"Everyone is on it but me."

Their friends are all on an app or a chat they are not.

"I want you to be connected with your friends. Let us look at this together and work out whether it is designed for your age and what the rules would be if you joined."

WHY Blanket refusal at this stage pushes the conversation underground.

SOMETHING WENT WRONG

"If I tell you, will you take my phone?"

"I need you to hear this properly. If you ever see something on your phone that scares you, or someone sends you something horrible, or you get into something you cannot get out of, you come and show me, and the phone stays yours. I will not take it off you for telling me. Telling me is the thing that keeps it."

WHY Children go quiet when telling costs them the phone.

Screenshots. Anything upsetting can come to you as a screenshot, and it costs them nothing. The one exception: a nude or sexual picture of anyone under 18 is never screenshotted, copied or sent on, not even to you. They just come and tell you.